



Enraged, she threw her racquet at him. Nastase also nearly got into a fistfight with intensely competitive Cliff Richey during a Paris final, and Nicki Spear, a mild-mannered Yugoslav, tried to slug Nasty, who had cursed him and his female relatives in a Boston doubles match. Nasty's obnoxious behavior in a Rome doubles final caused a near-riot that police had to be summoned to quell. And who can forget his infamous 1979 US Open match against McEnroe when fights broke out among dangerously inebriated spectators protesting Nasty's disqualification for repeatedly arguing a point penalty.

What made Nastase tick? In 1976, the popular psychologist Dr. Joyce Brothers speculated about his aberrant behavior in *Tennis* magazine. "With children, temper tantrums are normal. When older people act up, it's usually because they're getting something out of it. Nastase likes attention and because tennis has been considered a gentleman's game, he keeps his opponents so shook up they can't concentrate."

This decade, Nick Kyrgios, Benoit

Paire, and Alexander Bublik crave attention so much and compete so little that they masochistically self-destruct with underhand serves and other foolish shots on big points. They haven't figured out the balance between showmanship and smart shot selection.

The worst culprit

The worst culprit, though, is Gael Monfils, a 37-year-old Frenchman. Pundits have raved about his breathtaking athleticism since he won his nation's Under-13 and Under-14 100-meter Sprint Championships and starred in the juniors.

Recently on social media, Monfils said, "People don't let you believe in your own dreams. People don't know you. This is why I try to have interactions with my real fans. I don't need to win 20 tournaments, but if I win one match here, another match there, this is what it is about."

That cavalier, low-expectations, uncompetitive attitude has often been what it's about for *Le Monf*. When he lost the fifth set 6-0 to Andy Murray at the 2014 French Open, former world No. 1 Andy Roddick

tweeted that Monfils put in a "horrible effort," adding "showboats when winning and rolls over when down."

After his 6-4, 7-5 loss to Poland's Jerzy Janowicz at the 2015 Cincinnati Masters, Tracy Austin, a *Tennis Channel* analyst and two-time US Open champion renowned for her steely competitiveness, accused the well-liked Frenchman of not trying his best — the worst sin an athlete can commit. "To not give 100 percent and be so blatant about it, I think it's disrespectful. It looked like an exhibition tennis. We've seen that way too many times with him. With Gael, it's so difficult to watch because you know his upside ceiling could be so big, but he just goes away and doesn't even try."

Several years ago, during what should have been the prime of his career, Gael admitted he cared more about entertaining than winning. What a sad admission for any professional athlete. His job was to compete, compete tenaciously for every point. In a parallel way, his job was to train rigorously so he would not get exhausted in the middle of matches, which he sometimes did.